Military intelligence officers, ‘special task force’ personnel, intelligence bureau operatives and a host of ‘freelance’ professionals occasionally masquerading as ‘insurgents’ to give effect to ‘special operations’ are freely written about in magazines like *Force*—a journal specifically catering to the professional needs and realities of ‘armed forces and security personnel’ in India.

There is no reason to suppose that the tacticians and strategists of the ‘intelligence community’ that owes its fealty to the Indian state do not, from time to time, have to consider it necessary to ‘create’ or manufacture instances of terrorism, when it suits the purposes of the state to do so. This is standard practice worldwide, especially under the conditions of the ‘global war against terror’, and there is no reason to suppose that Indian intelligence professionals are anything but abreast of key global trends in this regard.[2]

This ‘creation’ of terrorism is something that generally requires a calibrated media strategy and information management such that the bodies and actions that characterize a particular operation can be ‘rendered’ in a manner that is convincing and useful. The overproduction of enthusiastic and detailed reports on the supposed backgrounds, past lives and actions of the primary accused in the 13 December case bear an overwhelming stamp of such a close alignment between the need to create a body of convincing ‘evidence’ on the part of the security and intelligence community and the media’s thirst for a meaty story. Television channels and newspapers routinely projected the accused and arrested as ‘terrorist masterminds and co-conspirators’ without even the caveat that this was as alleged by their captors.

The enthusiastic reportage of the ‘arrest’ of the prime accused Afzal, Shaukat Husain and Geelani, which in some instances bordered on the hysterical, particularly in the week following 14 December (when Geelani was detained under POTA), is particularly noteworthy. In the stories that began to make their appearance, the swoops were a result of the brilliant investigations carried out by the police on the mobile phone records of the phones and sim cards found on the bodies of the alleged slain terrorists. Not one newspaper or television channel paused to ask why a group of terrorists going on what could clearly be a ‘suicide mission’ or one in which the chances of their being captured was very high, should carry identity cards, diaries detailing their actions and plans and mobile phones that could be made to yield entire directories of their contacts. No one paused to ask what can only be very reasonable questions about the veracity and provenance of these